It’s possible to read a file synchronously in Node.js and then convert the response to an array:

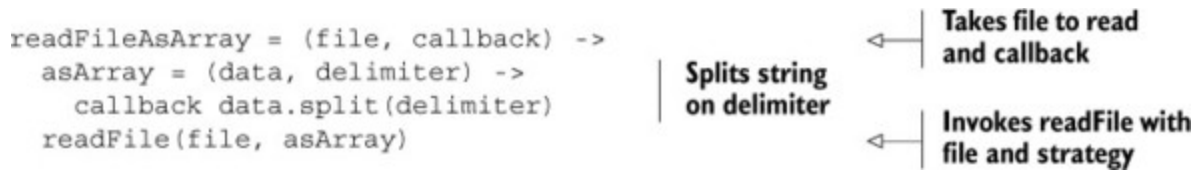
```
fs = require 'fs'
raw = fs.readFileSync 'competitors', 'utf-8'
competitors = raw.split /\n/
```

But the standard approach is to read the file asynchronously and pass in a callback that’s invoked when the file is read:

```
readFile = (file, callback) ->
  fs.readFile file, 'utf-8', (error, response) ->
    throw error if error
    callback response
```

Reading files asynchronously is the standard approach because doing things synchronously can have disastrous consequences, as you’ll soon see.

A function to get an array of the competitors asynchronously invokes the `readFile` function with another callback function that converts the response to an array:



This function can be invoked with a callback that prints the resulting array:

```
readFileAsArray 'competitors', (result) ->
  console.log result
# ['0212: Turnbill, Geralyn'
# '0055: Spielvogel, Cierra'
# '0072: Renyer, Connie'
# '0011: Engholm, Ciara'
# '0088: Gitting, Estrella']
```

The asynchronous version might seem a bit inside out. So why bother doing things asynchronously? To appreciate this technique, try processing the data from the file.